

Instructor: Date:

Learner: Regional Branch:

Program: Center:

CONTENT

- Let's Start! • Let's Explore! • Let's Practice! • Extension Activity • Target Words • Learning Points



Let's Start!

Writing Spot: Illusionist and stunt performer Harry Houdini!



Learning Outcome

Describe hypothetical situations in written and spoken interactions according to work and social contexts.

Can Do Statements

- I can write about fame and work.
- I can write about what was done.
- I can speculate about the past in a written way.

Ask your partner:

- Can you or anyone you know perform magic tricks? What kind?
- What kind of personal qualities would you need to perform stunts and illusions?





Let's Explore!

Houdini was a master **illusionist*** and performer. How much do we know about his past?

* An "illusionist" is an entertainer who performs magic tricks.



Instructions: Read the text aloud.

Many people say that Harry Houdini was the most famous magician of all time. Today, when people hear the name Houdini, they think of the ability to escape from any restraint or difficult situation.

Houdini's early childhood was full of mystery. His original name was Ehrich Weiss. He was born on March 24, 1874, in Budapest. When Houdini was four years old, he was taken to the United States by his parents. His life could have been very different if his family had stayed in Europe.

It was often claimed by Houdini that he was born in Wisconsin. Historians, however, later concluded that he was born in Hungary. Even today, people from Appleton claim that their city was Houdini's birthplace. Houdini might have wanted to hide his immigrant origins.

Houdini had a poor childhood. The Weiss children had to work from an early age. By the time he was eight years old, Ehrich was already selling newspapers and working as a shoeshine boy. It must have been a challenging time for the family. Eventually Ehrich ended up in New York, when he was about 13 years old. As a teenager in New York, Ehrich became interested in magic. He may have felt that this was another way of making a living. Calling himself Ehrich the Great, he began performing card tricks and other simple tricks for money. His career started to take off.

One day, he read a book that changed his life. The book, *The Memoirs of Robert-Houdin*, was written by one of the world's greatest magicians. Ehrich was so influenced by what he read that he changed his name to Houdini. Little did he know that this up and coming star would eventually become even more famous than Robert-Houdin.





Let's Practice!

Before he was Houdini.

Instructions: Organize the mystery sentence. Move each word to place it in the correct order.

1. taken / parents / was / his / to / United / States / . / by / He

2. Wisconsin / born / in / It / that / claimed / . / he / was / was

3. of / world's / was / written / book / by / . / magicians / greatest / the / The / one

4. by / was influenced / what / Ehrich / read / he / .

5. performance / . / the / people / The / amazed / by / were



Let's Practice!

Let's hypothesize* about Houdini.

*"to hypothesize" means to guess or predict.

Instructions: Move the words from the box to correctly complete the sentences.

Word Bank

might not have realized / could have been / might have felt / might have wanted / must have been

- His life _____ very different if his family had stayed in Europe.
- Houdini _____ to hide his immigrant origins.
- It _____ a challenging time for the family.
- He _____ that this was another way of making a living.
- They _____ they were watching the great Houdini.



Extension Activity

Describe how to perform a magic trick, step by step.

Instructions: Complete the following steps. Fill in the Self-Assessment.

- Go online and discover how to perform a simple magic trick.
- Write out the procedure, step by step.
- Read the procedure out loud as you practice your trick.
- Perform the trick for a partner. See if they can guess how it was done.
- Perform the trick again, this time explaining the procedure.

Self-Assessment

Yes

No

I research a magic trick.

☐ ☐

I write out a step-by-step procedure.

☐ ☐

I practice reading instructions out loud.

☐ ☐

I narrate as I am performing an action.

☐ ☐


Target Words

- **shoeshine** (noun): someone who cleans and polishes shoes for a living
e.g. By the time he was eight years old, Ehrich was already selling newspapers and working as a shoeshine boy.
- **magic** (noun): the skill of performing tricks and illusions
e.g. As a teenager in New York, Ehrich became interested in magic.
- **restraint** (noun): something that keeps a person immobile, such as a rope or a belt
e.g. Today, when people hear the name Houdini, they think of the ability to escape from any restraint or difficult situation.
- **to claim** (verb): to say that something is true
e.g. Even today, people from Appleton claim that their city was Houdini's birthplace.
- **card trick** (noun): an illusion or deception performed with a deck of playing cards
e.g. Calling himself Ehrich the Great, he began performing card tricks and other simple tricks for money.
- **memoir** (noun): a written account of someone's own life and experiences
e.g. The book "The Memoirs of Robert-Houdin" was written by one of the world's greatest magicians.
- **make a living** (expression): to work; to earn money
e.g. He may have felt that this was another way of making a living.





Learning Points

Simple Past Passive

Sentences can be active or passive. Therefore, tenses also have "active forms" and "passive forms."

In active sentences, the thing doing the action is the subject of the sentence and the thing receiving the action is the object.

In passive sentences, the thing receiving the action is the subject of the sentence and the thing doing the action is optionally included near the end of the sentence. You can use the passive form if you think that the thing receiving the action is more important or should be emphasized.

Object + was / were + past participle

Example: *The weather was affected by the unexpected cold currents.*

Was / Were + object + past participle ... ?

Example: *Was the weather affected by the cold currents?*

Examples:

- *Ehrich was so influenced by what he read that he changed his name to Houdini.*
- *When Houdini was four years old, he was taken to the United States by his parents.*
- *"The Memoirs of Robert-Houdin" was written by one of the world's greatest magicians.*





Learning Points

Speculating About The Past

We often guess about past situations based on what we know. You can choose modals based on how certain you are about your speculation.

When you are almost 100 percent certain that something was possible, use *must have* or *had to have*.

We use **must** when we feel sure about something in the past. When you are less certain, use *may have*, *might have*, or *could have*. We use **might**, **may** or **could** to say that we think something was possible but we aren't sure.

- **must have** + past participle
- **might have / might not have** + past participle
- **could have / couldn't have** + past participle
- **may have / may not have** + past participle
- **can't have** + past participle

Examples:

- *It must have been a challenging time for the family.*
- *His life could have been very different if his family had stayed in Europe.*
- *He may have felt that this was another way of making a living.*
- *Houdini might have wanted to hide his immigrant origins.*

